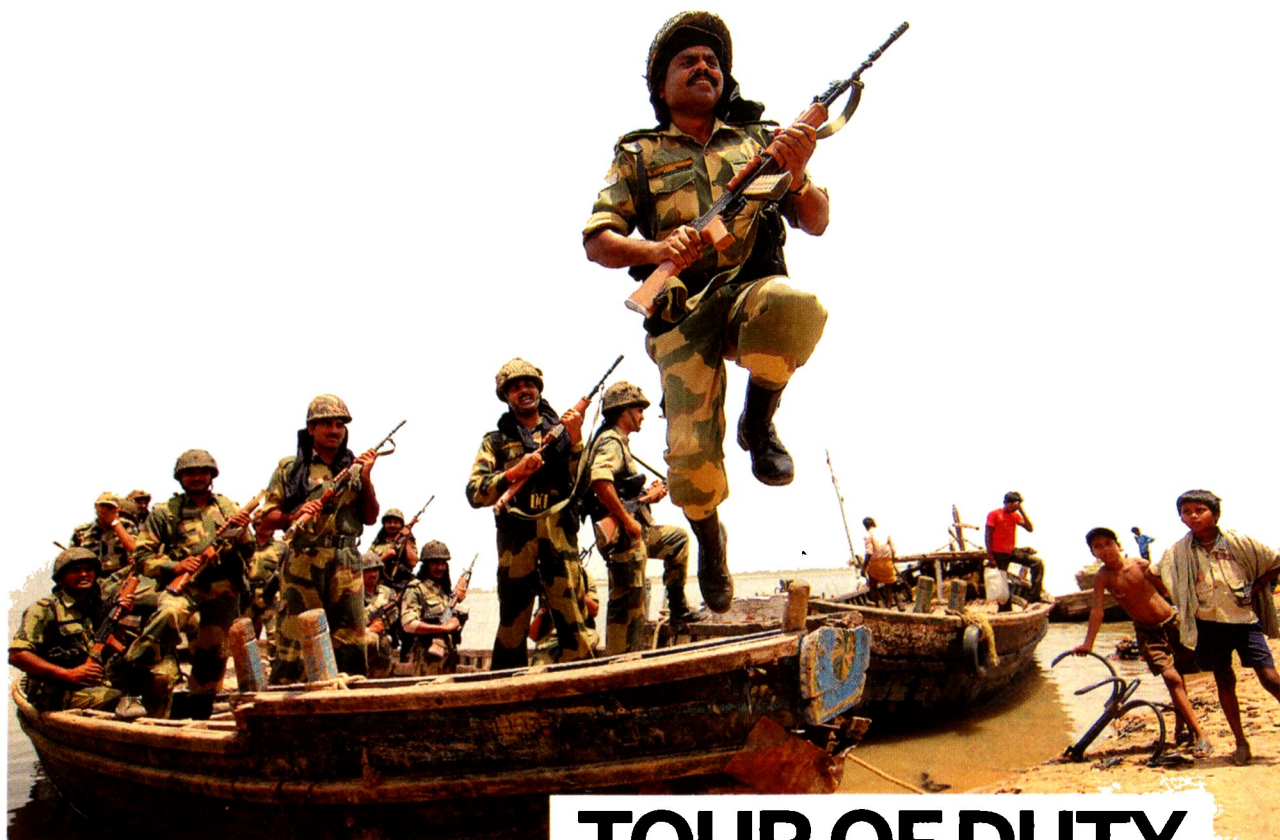




TOUR OF DUTY

BORDER SECURITY Force soldiers at Diyara near Patna, Bihar, on the eve of the fourth phase of polling for the general elections in the state. In order to secure the ballot, the 15th Lok Sabha elections required heavy mobilisation of security forces, and were staggered in five phases over a month.

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Parks and public gardens usually double up as love havens for couples—and even the Lucknow city administration recognises that. The erstwhile city of nawabs is fast undergoing revolutionary changes—and it's not just in the presence of malls and multiplexes but even in mindset. Condom-vending machines have helpfully been placed in the city's parks and gardens where many an amorous couple tends to wander. Condom manufacturers were given the go-ahead by the municipal corporations to install vending machines at Globe Park, which now is being called Condom Park by its frequent visitors. Ironically, when the state Government had favoured sex education in schools, the furore forced the plan to be shelved. The good folk of Lucknow now seem to have decided it is better to be safe than... uninformed.

by Subhash Mishra



CONDOM-VENDING MACHINES HAVE THOUGHTFULLY BEEN INSTALLED IN PARKS IN THE UTTAR PRADESH CAPITAL.